

SILVER CURRENT PRESS

The Quiet Craft

A Working Writer's Notebook

EXPANDED EDITION

Forty-five entries on fiction, poetry, memoir, revision, the business of submitting work, and the daily discipline of staying at the desk — each with an exercise and a page to write on, plus a bonus exercise for every part. Includes fifty-four writing prompts, a glossary of craft terms, a submission-log template, and a working writer's shelf of twenty-six further books.

A welcome gift for the Reader's Circle at authorjamesmulhern.com

The Quiet Craft: A Working Writer's Notebook — Expanded Edition

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This notebook is offered free to members of the Reader's Circle. You're welcome to print it, write in it, and share the sign-up link with other writers — please don't resell or republish the text itself.

Set in EB Garamond, Playfair Display, and Cinzel.

WELCOME

A Note Before You Begin

Thank you for joining the Reader's Circle. The first version of this notebook was nine entries long — a good start, but a thin one, and I kept hearing from readers who wanted more to work with. This is the notebook I meant to give you the first time: still built the same way, still meant to be written in rather than merely read, just considerably larger, and organized by the actual rooms of a writing life — fiction, poetry, memoir, revision, the business of sending work into the world, and the daily discipline of staying at the desk.

I've spent years publishing short stories and poems in more than 350 literary journals, teaching Art of Telling, and reading manuscripts for other writers as a developmental editor and copyeditor. Almost everything here I learned slowly, and mostly by getting it wrong first. None of it is a formula. Craft advice that works for one writer's sentence can be exactly wrong for another's — test everything here against your own ear and your own material, and keep only what earns its place.

The notebook is organized into seven parts. Part One covers the habits and doubts common to any writing life, regardless of form. Parts Two through Four turn to fiction, poetry, and memoir specifically — read the parts that match what you're working on now, or read all three anyway; craft in one form almost always sharpens the others. Part Five is about revision, which is where most of the real writing happens. Part Six is about the practical and often demoralizing business of submitting work. Part Seven is about the longer game — the habits that let a writing life last for decades rather than one good year.

After each entry there's a short prompt and room to write, and each of the seven parts closes with a longer bonus exercise. Use a pencil. Cross things out. That's what the page is for. At the back, you'll find fifty-four additional writing prompts organized by genre, a glossary of craft terms, a submission-log template you're welcome to photocopy or redraw in your own notebook, and a working writer's shelf of twenty-six books I actually recommend. Read one entry at a time, or all forty-five in a single long sitting — either is fine. Now go write something true.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How This Notebook Is Built

Each entry opens with a line from a writer who thought hard about the same problem, followed by a short reflection and a “Try This” prompt with space to respond. A few epigraphs are marked as a working note rather than credited to anyone else — those are my own margin notes, offered the same way I’d hand you a note before class.

Each part opens with a short introduction and closes with a longer “Part Exercise” — a bigger, slower prompt meant to take twenty minutes or more, for when a single-entry prompt isn’t enough runway. If you finish a part and want more starting points, the Fifty-Four Writing Prompts appendix near the back is organized by fiction, poetry, and memoir, so you can pull a fresh idea any time the page is blank and the problem isn’t craft, it’s simply not having anywhere to start.

The parts can be read in order or read out of order, depending on what you’re working on. A poet with no interest in query letters can skip straight from Part Three to Part Five. A memoirist can skip the fiction-specific entries in Part Two and still find plenty that applies — craft borrows across forms more than genre labels suggest.

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PART I

Foundations of a Working Writing Life

The habits and doubts common to any writing life, regardless of form. Read this part first — everything in Parts Two through Seven assumes you've already begun sitting down.

IN THIS PART

1. Begin Before You're Ready
2. The First Draft Is Not the Book
3. Write Toward the Specific
4. Silence Is Part of the Sentence
5. Cut What You're Proud Of
6. Keep a Small, Honest Notebook
7. Read as a Thief
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PART EXERCISE

Keep a single index card on your desk for one full week. Every day, write one true, specific sentence on it — something noticed, overheard, or felt. At the end of the week, read all seven sentences together and write for ten minutes on whatever connection between them surprises you.

ENTRY 1

Begin Before You're Ready

"I write to find out what I think."

— Joan Didion (paraphrased, widely attributed)

Every writer I've ever taught has told me some version of the same thing: I'm waiting until I have more time, more clarity, a better opening line. I understand the impulse. I've felt it before a blank page more times than I can count. But readiness is not a prerequisite for writing — it's usually a product of it.

The sentence that unlocks a story rarely arrives before you start. It arrives on page three, in a draft you were sure was going nowhere. Begin anyway. Begin badly, even. The page in front of you is more honest counsel than the one still in your head.

TRY THIS

Set a timer for ten minutes. Write the worst possible opening sentence to something you've been avoiding. Then write the sentence that comes after it.

ENTRY 2

The First Draft Is Not the Book

“The first draft of anything is garbage.”

— often attributed to Ernest Hemingway

Students in Art of Telling frequently apologize for their drafts, as though I expect to be handed a finished thing. I don't. A first draft's only job is to exist — to give you something to argue with, cut, and rebuild. Judging it as a finished piece is like judging a house by its scaffolding.

Give yourself permission to write badly on the way to writing well. The relief of that permission is often what gets a stalled piece moving again.

TRY THIS

Take one paragraph you've been unhappy with. Rewrite it three different ways, without judging any of them. Notice which one you reach for again tomorrow.

ENTRY 3

Write Toward the Specific

“Zoom in. What is the exact word?”

— Anton Chekhov, in a letter on craft

Chekhov famously advised a young writer to abandon “the moon glittered” for “the glint of light on broken glass.” The instinct to generalize — a nice house, a sad man, a long day — is the instinct to disappear. Specificity is what makes a reader believe you were actually there.

This applies whether you’re writing fiction, memoir, or a poem. The particular detail — the brand of the coffee, the exact color of a coat, the specific insult remembered for twenty years — does more work than any adjective piled on top of a vague noun.

TRY THIS

Take a sentence with a general noun in it (a room, a meal, a stranger). Replace the noun with the most specific version of it you can recall or invent.

ENTRY 4

Silence Is Part of the Sentence

“What is not said is as important as what is.”

— a note from Chekhov's letters, paraphrased

New writers often over-explain — stating the feeling a scene has already shown. Trust the reader more than that. What you withhold, what you let a character not say, is often the most active ingredient on the page.

In memoir especially, resist the urge to tell the reader what a memory means. Render it, and let the meaning arrive on its own, the way it actually does in life.

TRY THIS

Find a paragraph where you've explained a feeling outright (“I was heartbroken”). Delete the explanation and write only the physical details around it.

ENTRY 5

Cut What You're Proud Of

“Kill your darlings.”

— widely attributed to Sir Arthur Quiller-Couch

The sentence you're most pleased with is worth a second, suspicious look. Often it's performing for the writer, not serving the reader — a small fireworks display that stops the piece rather than moves it forward.

This is not a rule against beauty. It's a rule about allegiance: the paragraph should serve the story, not your ego. Cut the darling, save it in a separate file if you must, and see if the piece breathes better without it. It usually does.

TRY THIS

Find the sentence in your current draft you're proudest of. Remove it for one full read-through. Does anything go missing?

ENTRY 6

Keep a Small, Honest Notebook

“Fill your paper with the breathings of your heart.”

— William Wordsworth

Not a productivity system. Something closer to a compost heap — overheard lines, a color you can't stop thinking about, a sentence that arrived while you were half-asleep. Most of it you'll never use directly. That's fine. The habit of noticing is the actual craft; the notebook is just where the noticing lives until it's needed.

I've pulled lines out of notebooks a decade old and found they were exactly what a new story needed. Keep the notebook even when — especially when — you don't know yet what it's for.

TRY THIS

Write down one true, specific thing you noticed today — a phrase you overheard, a gesture, a smell. No context needed. Just the fact of it.

ENTRY 7

Read as a Thief

“Talent is a long patience.”

— Gustave Flaubert

I tell my students to read the way a thief cases a house — looking for how the thing was built, not just what it contains. When a paragraph moves you, stop and ask what, mechanically, it just did. How long were the sentences? Where did the writer choose to slow down?

Joyce, Chekhov, Alice Munro, Flannery O'Connor — whoever moves you — deserve this kind of close, working attention. Reading generously as a fan and reading closely as a craftsperson are two different skills. Both matter, but only one of them will improve your own sentences.

TRY THIS

Copy out, by hand, one paragraph from a writer you admire. Notice what your hand notices that your eye skipped.

ENTRY 8

Finish the Thing

“A poem is never finished, only abandoned.”

— often attributed to Paul Valéry

Perfectionism disguises itself as diligence, but it is often just fear wearing a respectable coat. At some point — not when the piece is perfect, because it never will be, but when it has said what it came to say — you have to let it go.

Finishing is a skill distinct from writing well, and it's the one most worth practicing deliberately. A finished, imperfect story teaches you things an endlessly revised, unfinished one never will. Finish this one. Then start the next.

TRY THIS

Name one piece you've been revising indefinitely. Set a real date — write it here — by which you'll call it done and send it somewhere.

PART II

Fiction: Building a Story That Moves

Fiction lives or dies on movement — of attention, of desire, of consequence. These seven entries cover the decisions that make a story move rather than sit still on the page.

IN THIS PART

1. Scene vs. Summary
2. Point of View Is a Decision, Not a Default
3. Dialogue Says What Silence Can't
4. Desire and Obstacle: The Engine of Plot
5. Setting Is Character
6. Structure: How Stories Actually Move
7. Endings Earn Themselves

PART EXERCISE

Take a single object from your own home. Write three short scenes, each under a page, in which three different characters interact with that same object for entirely different reasons. Notice how the object's meaning changes depending on who wants it and why.

ENTRY 9

Scene vs. Summary

“Try to leave out the part that readers tend to skip.”

— Elmore Leonard, on his ten rules of writing (2001)

Every story is a series of decisions about pace: where to slow down into a fully rendered scene, moment by moment, and where to speed up into summary, compressing weeks or years into a sentence. Beginning writers tend to summarize the moments that matter most and dramatize the ones that don't.

A useful test: if a moment changes something — a relationship, a decision, what a character wants — it usually deserves scene. If it's connective tissue getting a reader from one important moment to the next, summary will move faster and serve the story better.

TRY THIS

Find a scene in your draft that could be compressed to a sentence without losing anything essential. Compress it, and see what the extra room does for the scene beside it.

ENTRY 10

Point of View Is a Decision, Not a Default

“The house of fiction has—in short—not one window, but a million.”

— Henry James, preface to *The Portrait of a Lady* (1908)

First person, close third, distant third, second person, omniscient — each window onto the story shows a different house entirely. Writers often choose point of view by instinct and never revisit the choice, even when a draft is clearly straining against it.

Ask what your point of view can and cannot know. A close-third narrator confined to one character's head can't tell the reader what a second character is thinking — which is a constraint, but also the source of dramatic irony, suspense, and misunderstanding. Choose the window on purpose, and choose the one whose limits serve the story.

TRY THIS

Rewrite the opening paragraph of your draft in a different point of view than the one you're using. What becomes possible? What's lost?

ENTRY II

Dialogue Says What Silence Can't

“Dialogue is not conversation. It's what a character will say out loud, and everything ordinary removed.”

— a working note

Real conversation is full of filler — greetings, false starts, small talk that goes nowhere. Dialogue on the page has to earn every line, which means it is never a transcript of how people actually talk, only an illusion of one.

Good dialogue does at least two things at once: it advances the scene, and it reveals character through what's said and how. People rarely say exactly what they mean. Write toward what a character is avoiding saying as much as what they actually say.

TRY THIS

Take a page of dialogue from your draft. Cut every line of greeting, small talk, or exposition a character wouldn't actually need to say aloud. What's left?

ENTRY 12

Desire and Obstacle: The Engine of Plot

“Every character should want something, even if it is only a glass of water.”

— Kurt Vonnegut

Plot is not a sequence of events — it's a sequence of a character wanting something and running into resistance while trying to get it. A story with no clear desire, however small, tends to drift, no matter how well the sentences are made.

The desire doesn't need to be large. A character who wants nothing more than an uninterrupted afternoon can carry an entire story, provided the obstacles to that small want are specific and escalating. Name what your protagonist wants on any given page, and name what's in the way. If you can't answer both questions, neither can your reader.

TRY THIS

Write one sentence naming exactly what your protagonist wants in this scene, and one sentence naming exactly what's stopping them from getting it right now.

ENTRY 13

Setting Is Character

“Every story would be another story—and unrecognizable as art—if it took up its characters and plot and happened somewhere else.”

— Eudora Welty, “Place in Fiction” (1956)

Setting is too often treated as backdrop — a paragraph of description to get through before the real story starts. Welty’s point is sharper: place isn’t scenery, it’s the pressure that shapes what a character can want and what can happen to them.

A story set in a Boston triple-decker in 1975 is a different story than the same plot set in a Palm Springs bungalow in 2020, even with identical events. Ask what your setting makes possible that no other setting would, and let that particularity do real work rather than serve as furniture.

TRY THIS

Name one specific way your setting is shaping what your character can and can’t do in this scene — not what it looks like, what it constrains or allows.

ENTRY 14

Structure: How Stories Actually Move

“‘The king died and then the queen died’ is a story. ‘The king died, and then the queen died of grief’ is a plot.”

— E.M. Forster, *Aspects of the Novel* (1927)

Forster’s distinction is worth returning to at every draft stage: a story is simply what happened, in order. A plot is what happened, connected by cause and consequence. Structure is the arrangement of that causality — what the reader learns, and when, and in what order relative to the events themselves.

You don’t need a strict three-act outline to have structure. Nonlinear stories, frame narratives, and braided timelines are all structures — they just rearrange the causal chain rather than removing it. What a structure can’t do is disappear. If a reader can’t articulate why one thing leads to the next, the structure isn’t doing its job yet, whatever shape it takes.

TRY THIS

Write a one-sentence summary of your story using “and then” only where events are truly disconnected, and “because” or “so” everywhere causality actually exists. How much of your story is still “and then”?

ENTRY 15

Endings Earn Themselves

“One must not put a loaded rifle on the stage if no one is thinking of firing it.”

— Anton Chekhov, letter to Aleksandr Lazarev, November 1889

The principle now known as Chekhov’s gun runs in both directions: everything you introduce with weight owes the reader a payoff, and every ending owes its power to something set up earlier, not to a twist that arrives from nowhere.

A satisfying ending doesn’t have to be happy, or even resolved — but it has to feel earned, which means the material for it has to already be on the page before the final scene. If your ending surprises you as the writer, check whether it also feels inevitable in hindsight. The best endings do both.

TRY THIS

List every object, line, or detail introduced in your first page. Which of them reappears — or should — by the end?

PART III

Poetry: Compression and Music

Poetry works by different rules than prose — compression instead of expansion, the line instead of the sentence as the basic unit. Six entries on the specific machinery of a poem.

IN THIS PART

1. The Line Is a Unit of Meaning
2. Image Before Idea
3. Sound Carries Argument
4. Form as Container, Not Cage
5. Metaphor: The Machinery of Comparison
6. Revision in Poems: Cutting to the Bone

PART EXERCISE

Write the same short poem three times: once as a strict form (a sonnet or villanelle), once as tightly compressed free verse, and once as a prose poem with no line breaks at all. Compare what each version makes possible that the others don't.

ENTRY 16

The Line Is a Unit of Meaning

“A line break is a decision, not a typographical accident.”

— a working note

In prose, the sentence is the basic unit; in poetry, it's the line, and the line does not have to end where the sentence would. Where you break a line creates emphasis — the last word before the break and the first word after it both get a small spotlight the middle of a line doesn't.

Read your poem breaking only where the sentence naturally pauses, then read it again breaking somewhere unexpected — mid-phrase, on a preposition, on a verb. Notice what each choice does to pacing, suspense, and which words get underlined by their position.

TRY THIS

Take three lines of a poem you're working on. Rewrite the line breaks twice, in two different places than where they currently fall. Read all three versions aloud.

ENTRY 17

Image Before Idea

“No ideas but in things.”

— William Carlos Williams, Paterson

Williams's dictum is a corrective against poems that announce their meaning before earning it. A poem that states “grief is heavy” has told the reader an idea; a poem that renders the specific weight of a coat still hanging by the door has given the reader an image the idea can grow out of on its own.

This doesn't mean poems can't think — some of the best ones think hard. It means the thinking works better when it arrives through a concrete, sensory particular rather than in the abstract. Trust the object to carry the abstraction; don't state the abstraction and hope an object shows up to decorate it.

TRY THIS

Find the most abstract line in your current poem (grief, time, love, loss used as a bare noun). Replace it with a specific object or image that implies the same idea without naming it.

ENTRY 18

Sound Carries Argument

“The best place to get the abstract sound of sense is from voices behind a door that cuts off the words.”

— Robert Frost, letter to John Bartlett, July 1913

Frost's insight is that a poem's meaning travels partly through pure sound — rhythm, stress, the music of it — independent of the words' dictionary definitions. You can often tell a poem's emotional register from its sound alone, the way you can tell a mood from voices through a wall.

This is why reading a poem aloud reveals problems silent reading misses. A line that scans cleanly on the page can trip in the mouth; a line that looks plain can carry real weight once you hear where the stresses actually fall.

TRY THIS

Read your poem aloud, slowly, and mark every syllable where your voice naturally lands hardest. Does the stress pattern match where the poem's meaning actually lives?

ENTRY 19

Form as Container, Not Cage

“Form is never more than an extension of content.”

— Robert Creeley, cited in Charles Olson's “Projective Verse” (1950)

Whether you write in strict form — sonnets, villanelles, sestinas — or free verse, the form isn't decoration applied after the fact. It's part of what the poem means. A villanelle's obsessive repetition can enact obsession itself; a poem that fractures into fragments on the page can enact the fracturing it describes.

Free verse is not the absence of form — it's form determined by the poem's own internal logic rather than an inherited pattern. Either way, ask what your form is doing, not just what rules it's following or breaking.

TRY THIS

Name one formal choice in your poem — stanza length, repetition, line length, rhyme or its absence. Write one sentence on what that choice enacts, not just what it looks like.

ENTRY 20

Metaphor: The Machinery of Comparison

“The greatest thing by far is to have a command of metaphor.”

— Aristotle, Poetics

A metaphor works by claiming two unlike things are, in some way, the same thing — and the friction between how unlike they are and how true the comparison feels is where the charge comes from. A metaphor that's too obvious (life is a journey) generates no friction; one that's too obscure generates confusion instead of insight.

The strongest metaphors usually come from specific, lived material rather than abstract browsing for a clever comparison. What does grief actually remind you of, concretely, from your own experience — not what grief is supposed to remind a poem of?

TRY THIS

Write three different metaphors for the same feeling or idea in your poem. Keep only the one that surprised you while you were writing it.

ENTRY 21

Revision in Poems: Cutting to the Bone

“A line will take us hours maybe; / Yet if it does not seem a moment’s thought, / Our stitching and unstitching has been naught.”

— W.B. Yeats, “Adam’s Curse” (1902)

Poems reveal their weak spots faster than prose does, precisely because there is so little room to hide a slack line. A single unearned word in a twelve-line poem is far more visible — and far more damaging — than the same word buried in a page of prose.

Revision in poetry is often subtractive rather than additive: not what more does this poem need, but what can be removed without the poem losing anything essential. Read through a draft asking of every single word: does this word earn its place, or is it there because the line needed to be filled?

TRY THIS

Take your shortest current poem and cut it by a third — not by trimming evenly, but by removing whichever lines do the least work. What’s left?

PART IV

Memoir and Personal Essay: Writing the True

Memoir asks different questions than fiction — not what's plausible, but what's true, and true to whom. Six entries on memory, ethics, and the shape of a life on the page.

IN THIS PART

1. Memory Is Not a Recording
2. What Happened vs. What It Means
3. Writing About the Living: Ethics and Courage
4. Scene, Reflection, and the Braided Essay
5. Finding the Universal in the Particular
6. The Reader Wants Truth, Not Perfection

PART EXERCISE

Choose one photograph you actually have of yourself at a specific age. Write for fifteen minutes describing only what's in the frame, in present tense, as though you're seeing it for the first time. Then write a separate paragraph on what the photograph doesn't show that you remember anyway.

ENTRY 22

Memory Is Not a Recording

“You are not reporting a videotape. You are reconstructing a memory, and the reconstruction is itself part of the story.”

— a working note

Memoir writers often stall on a false premise: that the job is to recall events with perfect accuracy, and any gap in memory is a failure. But memory doesn't work like a recording — it reconstructs, compresses, and reorders every time it's accessed, which is a fact about how brains work, not a flaw in your particular memory.

This doesn't give you license to invent. It does mean that where you're unsure, saying so on the page — “I don't remember what she said, only that I flinched” — is often more honest, and more interesting, than false certainty.

TRY THIS

Write one paragraph about a remembered scene, marking in brackets every detail you're genuinely unsure of. Notice whether the uncertainty itself belongs in the final draft.

ENTRY 23

What Happened vs. What It Means

“Every memoir has a situation and a story. The situation is what happened; the story is the emotional experience the writer is actually preoccupied with.”

— an idea developed by Vivian Gornick in *The Situation and the Story* (2001)

The situation of a memoir might be: my mother was ill for a decade. The story — what the piece is actually about, underneath the situation — might be: I learned to stop needing her approval. A memoirist who confuses the two produces a competent account of events with no discovered meaning underneath.

You often don't know your story until well into drafting. That's normal. Write the situation first if you need to, then keep asking what you were actually preoccupied with while it was happening, and revise toward that.

TRY THIS

Write one sentence describing your piece's situation (what happened) and a separate sentence describing its story (what it's actually about). If they're identical, keep digging.

ENTRY 24

Writing About the Living: Ethics and Courage

“You own everything that happened to you. Tell your stories.”

— Anne Lamott, *Bird by Bird* (1994)

Lamott’s permission is real, and worth returning to whenever a memoir stalls out of guilt about other people in the story. You have the right to your own experience and your own account of it, even when that account is unflattering to someone else, even someone you love.

That right comes with responsibility, not a veto. Consider changing identifying details for people who didn’t choose to be public, distinguish your interpretation from documented fact where it matters, and ask honestly whether you’re writing to understand something or simply to wound. Most memoirists find the writing gets braver, not crueler, once they stop trying to be fair to everyone and start trying to be honest.

TRY THIS

Name one person in your draft you’ve been softening out of guilt. Write the unsoftened version privately, even if it never becomes the version you publish.

ENTRY 25

Scene, Reflection, and the Braided Essay

“The essay that only remembers is a diary. The essay that only reflects is a sermon. The best ones do both, in the same breath.”

— a working note

Memoir and personal essay generally move between two modes: scene, which renders a remembered moment the way fiction renders one, and reflection, where the older, writing self makes sense of it. A piece that's all scene reads like an anecdote with no discovered meaning; a piece that's all reflection reads like an argument with no evidence.

A braided essay takes this further, interweaving a personal narrative thread with a second, seemingly separate thread — a piece of research, a natural history, another person's story — letting the two illuminate each other without either explaining the other outright.

TRY THIS

Mark your draft's paragraphs as either scene or reflection. If one mode dominates by a wide margin, choose one paragraph to convert to the other.

ENTRY 26

Finding the Universal in the Particular

“The more precisely you describe your own grandmother, the more readers recognize their own.”

— a working note

New memoirists sometimes worry their material is too small, too personal, or too specific to matter to a stranger. The opposite is usually true: readers connect to precise, particular detail far more reliably than to generalized statements meant to be universally relatable.

“We all feel loss” invites no one in. The exact brand of cigarette your grandfather smoked on the porch, and the specific way he tapped the pack against his palm before opening it, invites a reader into a moment they’ve never lived and somehow still recognize. Trust the particular; the universal will follow it in, uninvited.

TRY THIS

Find the most general sentence in your draft. Rewrite it using only specific, sensory detail from your own memory — no abstractions allowed.

ENTRY 27

The Reader Wants Truth, Not Perfection

“Readers forgive an unflattering narrator. They rarely forgive a narrator who insists they were right all along.”

— a working note

The most common weakness in early memoir drafts isn't a lack of skill — it's a narrator too protective of their own image. A writer who presents themselves as consistently wise, patient, or blameless produces a narrator readers instinctively distrust, because that isn't how anyone actually experiences their own life.

Complicate yourself on the page. Show the moment you were petty, wrong, or afraid, not just the moment you understood something. A memoirist willing to be unflattering earns a trust that a flawless narrator never will.

TRY THIS

Find a moment in your draft where you come across as entirely reasonable. Add one honest detail about what you actually did or felt that complicates that impression.

PART V

Revision: Where the Real Writing Happens

First drafts discover what a piece is about. Revision is where it actually becomes the piece. Six entries on doing that work well.

IN THIS PART

1. Let It Rest Before You Revise
2. Macro Before Micro
3. Reading Aloud Reveals the Lie
4. Get Feedback Before You're Ready For It
5. Working With an Editor
6. Know When a Draft Is Actually Done

PART EXERCISE

Take a finished draft you haven't looked at in over a month. Before rereading it, write from memory what you think it's about and where you think it's weakest. Then reread it and compare your memory against the actual page — the gap between the two is usually exactly where revision needs to happen.

ENTRY 28

Let It Rest Before You Revise

“Vigorous writing is concise. A sentence should contain no unnecessary words — for the same reason that a machine should contain no unnecessary parts.”

— William Strunk Jr. and E.B. White, *The Elements of Style* (1959)

You cannot see a draft clearly the day you finish it — you’re still too close to what you meant to say to notice what’s actually on the page. A week of distance, or even a few days, lets you read your own work with something closer to a stranger’s eyes, which is exactly the eyes revision requires.

This is uncomfortable advice for anyone on a deadline, but it’s worth protecting whenever you can. The efficiency Strunk and White describe — no unnecessary words — is almost impossible to see in your own sentences the same day you wrote them.

TRY THIS

Pull out a draft you finished at least a week ago and haven’t reread since. Read the first page cold. What jumps out now that didn’t before?

ENTRY 29

Macro Before Micro

“Fix the story before you fix the sentence. A beautifully polished scene in the wrong place is still in the wrong place.”

— a working note

It's tempting to revise line by line from the first sentence forward, polishing as you go. But if a scene needs to move, get cut, or get restructured entirely, all that careful line-editing was spent on material that's about to change anyway.

Do structural revision first: does the story or essay move in the right order, does every scene earn its place, does the ending follow from what's actually on the page. Only once the shape is right does it make sense to spend time perfecting individual sentences.

TRY THIS

Outline your draft's current structure in one line per scene or section. Would a different order serve the material better? Try reordering the outline before touching a single sentence.

ENTRY 30

Reading Aloud Reveals the Lie

“A sentence that's hard to say aloud is usually a sentence that's hard to understand, whatever it looks like on the page.”

— a working note

Reading a draft aloud — actually aloud, not silently in your head — exposes problems silent reading lets slide: sentences that are grammatically fine but unspeakable, rhythms that clunk, repeated words your eye skips but your ear catches immediately.

It also reveals pacing problems no amount of silent rereading will show you. If you run out of breath in the middle of a sentence, or find yourself speeding up through a passage that's supposed to be slow and contemplative, the prose is telling you something the page alone won't.

TRY THIS

Read one full page of your draft aloud, at a normal speaking pace, without stopping to fix anything. Mark every place you stumbled, and only then go back to see why.

ENTRY 31

Get Feedback Before You're Ready For It

"The manuscript that's been revised in total isolation for two years rarely improves in the third."

— a working note

Writers often wait to show work to anyone until it feels finished — which means outside feedback arrives too late to meaningfully change the architecture, only the surface. A trusted early reader who can flag a structural problem while it's still cheap to fix is worth more than a dozen readers of a nearly finished draft.

Choose readers deliberately. You want someone who reads in or near your genre, who will tell you what isn't working and not just what they liked, and whose taste you actually respect — not necessarily the person most available or most enthusiastic.

TRY THIS

Name one person whose feedback you've been avoiding because you're not ready to hear it. What would it cost to send them this draft today instead of after one more revision pass?

ENTRY 32

Working With an Editor

“A good editorial letter doesn't tell you what to write. It tells you what the manuscript is already trying to become.”

— a working note

As someone who reads manuscripts for other writers, I can tell you the most useful editorial feedback rarely arrives as a list of instructions to follow mechanically. It arrives as a set of observations — here's where I got confused, here's where the tension dropped, here's a question the manuscript raised and never answered — that you're free to disagree with.

A good editor works from what your manuscript is trying to do, not from what they would have written instead. If a note doesn't resonate with your own sense of the piece, you're allowed to set it aside. If several unrelated readers flag the same spot, that's worth taking seriously even if no single note by itself convinces you.

TRY THIS

Reread the last piece of feedback you received. Separate the notes into two columns: observations about what's happening on the page, and instructions about what to do about it. Which column do you trust more?

ENTRY 33

Know When a Draft Is Actually Done

“A poem is never finished, only abandoned.”

— often attributed to Paul Valéry (see also Part One, Entry VIII)

The same principle from Part One applies with more force in revision, where it's easy to mistake continued tinkering for continued improvement. A useful test: are your recent changes making the piece more itself, or are they just moving words around because stopping feels risky?

If you can no longer tell whether a change made the draft better or worse, you've likely reached the point of diminishing returns — which is different from the piece being flawless. It means it's ready to leave your desk, even though it's not, and never will be, perfect.

TRY THIS

List the last three changes you made to this draft. Did each one clearly improve the piece, or were you circling?

PART VI

The Business of Being a Writer

Writing well and building a body of published work are related but separate skills. Seven entries on submitting, querying, and the practical mechanics of getting work into the world.

IN THIS PART

1. Rejection Is Correspondence, Not Verdict
2. Understanding Literary Journals and Tiers
3. Cover and Query Letters That Don't Apologize
4. Building a Body of Work Over Time
5. Choosing Your Path: Traditional, Small Press, Self-Publishing
6. Contests, Residencies, and Grants
7. Building Community: Workshops, Readers, and Editors

PART EXERCISE

Build a submission list of ten journals or venues genuinely suited to one finished piece, using the Submission Log at the back of this notebook. Rank them from most to least ambitious, and send the piece to at least one venue in the top half of the list before you send it anywhere considered safer.

ENTRY 34

Rejection Is Correspondence, Not Verdict

“I have not failed. I've just found 10,000 ways that won't work.”

— attributed to Thomas Edison

Having sent work out to more than 350 literary journals over the years, I can promise you: rejection is simply the ordinary weather of a writing life, not a referendum on whether you should be doing this. A form rejection means an editor made a decision about fit, timing, or their own reading mood — not a definitive judgment on the work's worth.

Keep a record of where you've sent something and when. Let each rejection be data, not verdict. Then send the piece out again. The story that's rejected nine times and accepted on the tenth is not a rare exception — it's closer to the norm.

TRY THIS

List three places (journals, contests, agents, readers) you could send a piece this month. Commit to sending it to just one before the month ends.

ENTRY 35

Understanding Literary Journals and Tiers

“A journal’s acceptance rate tells you almost nothing about whether it’s the right home for this particular piece.”

— a working note

Literary journals range enormously — from long-established quarterlies with acceptance rates under one percent to newer online magazines actively looking to build a readership, and both can be exactly right for a given piece depending on tone, length, and subject matter, not just prestige.

Read a journal’s recent issues before submitting, not just its submission guidelines. A piece that would be a strong fit for one publication’s aesthetic can be a poor fit for another with an identical acceptance rate. Building a mental map of who publishes what you write is slower than mass-submitting, but it dramatically improves your odds per submission.

TRY THIS

Pick one journal you’ve never read closely. Read its three most recent published pieces in your genre before deciding whether to submit there.

ENTRY 36

Cover and Query Letters That Don't Apologize

“The cover letter's only job is to get out of the way of the work.”

— a working note

The most common mistake in a cover letter isn't a lack of polish — it's over-explanation. Editors and agents don't need a summary of why the piece matters, a defense of its themes, or an apology for its shortcomings. They need the piece's title, length, and genre, a one- or two-line description if the venue requests one, and a short, professional bio.

Confidence reads as competence, even when you don't feel confident. Avoid hedging language (“I hope you might consider,” “this is probably not right for you, but”) and simply state what the piece is and let it speak for itself.

TRY THIS

Reread your standard cover letter. Cut every sentence that explains, defends, or apologizes for the work rather than simply describing it.

ENTRY 37

Building a Body of Work Over Time

“A career is built out of dozens of small, unglamorous acceptances, not one lucky break.”

— a working note

It's tempting to measure a writing life by its highest moment — the prestigious acceptance, the book deal, the prize. But most working writers' actual bodies of work are built from a much longer, quieter accumulation: dozens of smaller acceptances, a growing set of publication credits, a readership built one journal issue at a time.

Publication credits compound. A strong smaller-journal credit today can be exactly the credential that gets a later piece a serious read from a more prominent editor. Don't wait for a breakthrough before building the steady record that makes a breakthrough more likely.

TRY THIS

List your five most recent submissions or publications, however small. What pattern, if any, do you notice about where your work has found a home?

ENTRY 38

Choosing Your Path: Traditional, Small Press, Self-Publishing

“The question isn’t which path is legitimate. It’s which path serves this particular book.”

— a working note

Traditional publishing offers an advance, editorial and marketing support, and wide distribution, in exchange for a long timeline, less creative control, and a competitive gatekeeping process. Small independent presses often offer more creative control and a closer editorial relationship, with more limited marketing reach.

Self-publishing offers full control and speed, in exchange for taking on every other role — editing, design, distribution, marketing — yourself or by hiring it out.

None of these paths is inherently more legitimate than the others; each suits different books, goals, and temperaments. A niche poetry collection, a commercial thriller, and a specialized nonfiction guide often have genuinely different right answers.

TRY THIS

Name what you actually want from this particular book — income, wide readership, creative control, speed to publication, a specific niche audience — and rank those priorities honestly before choosing a path.

ENTRY 39

Contests, Residencies, and Grants

“An entry fee buys you a reading, not a guarantee — treat it as the cost of a lottery ticket you’d be glad to buy even if you never win.”

— a working note

Contests and residencies can offer meaningful validation, funding, and dedicated writing time, but they operate on odds most writers underestimate. A well-regarded contest may receive thousands of entries for a handful of prizes; a competitive residency may accept a small fraction of applicants.

Apply selectively and strategically rather than everywhere at once: entry fees add up, and a scattershot approach to residencies costs real time in applications that could go toward writing instead. Reserve contest and residency applications for opportunities genuinely suited to your work, and treat any acceptance as a welcome surprise rather than an expectation.

TRY THIS

Research one contest or residency relevant to your current project. Note its fee, deadline, and what past winners’ or fellows’ work has looked like, before deciding whether to apply.

ENTRY 40

Building Community: Workshops, Readers, and Editors

“A writing life sustained entirely alone is rare, and rarely as productive as its writer believes.”

— a working note

Writing itself is solitary, but a sustainable writing life usually isn't. Workshops offer structured feedback and deadlines; a small circle of trusted readers offers honest response outside a classroom setting; editors and mentors offer a longer view of your work than any single piece can show.

Community also does something less measurable: it normalizes the ordinary difficulty of the work, so a slow month or a string of rejections doesn't feel like private failure. Seek out people whose honesty you trust more than people who simply make you feel good, and be that kind of reader for others in return.

TRY THIS

Name one writing community — a workshop, a critique group, even a single trusted reader — you could join or reach out to this month.

PART VII

Sustaining the Writing Life

Five entries on the longer game — the habits, defenses, and perspective that let a writing life last for decades rather than one good year.

IN THIS PART

1. Protecting Time Like It's Money
2. Reading as Fuel
3. Teaching What You Know
4. Comparison, Envy, and the Long Table
5. A Long Game: Careers, Not Launches

PART EXERCISE

Write a one-page letter to yourself, dated five years from today, describing the writing life you actually want by then — not the acclaim, the daily shape of it. Seal it, date it, and put it somewhere you'll genuinely find again.

ENTRY 41

Protecting Time Like It's Money

“How we spend our days is, of course, how we spend our lives.”

— Annie Dillard, *The Writing Life* (1989)

Writing time rarely appears on its own; it has to be defended against every other reasonable-seeming demand on a given day. Treating an hour of writing time with the same seriousness you'd treat a paid appointment — protected on the calendar, not sacrificed first when something else comes up — changes what actually gets written over a year.

This is especially true for writers teaching, editing, or holding down other work. The writing rarely gets what's left over after everything else is handled; it only gets written if it's scheduled first, with the same weight as anything else on the calendar.

TRY THIS

Look at your calendar for the coming week. Block one specific hour for writing, and treat it exactly as you would an appointment you can't cancel.

ENTRY 42

Reading as Fuel

“If you don't have time to read, you don't have the time (or the tools) to write. Simple as that.”

— Stephen King, *On Writing* (2000)

Part One's entry on reading as a thief is about close, mechanical attention to craft. This entry is about something simpler: reading widely and constantly, as fuel rather than study, is what keeps a writer's sense of language, possibility, and ambition alive between projects.

It's easy to let reading time collapse when a deadline looms, on the theory that every hour should go to the writing itself. In practice, writers who stop reading tend to run dry faster than writers who protect reading time even when it feels like a luxury they can't afford.

TRY THIS

Name the last book you finished purely for pleasure, with no professional or craft-study reason. If you can't remember one, start one tonight.

ENTRY 43

Teaching What You Know

“You don’t fully understand a piece of craft until you’ve had to explain it to someone who disagrees with you.”

— a working note

Teaching Art of Telling has taught me more about my own craft habits than almost anything else I’ve done — not because students need to be told what I already know, but because explaining a craft principle out loud, to a skeptical room, exposes exactly which parts of your own instincts you actually understand and which parts you’ve simply been repeating.

You don’t need a classroom to get this benefit. Explaining a craft problem to another writer, in a workshop or over coffee, forces the same clarifying pressure. If you can’t explain why a choice works, you may not yet understand it as well as you think you do.

TRY THIS

Pick one craft principle you rely on instinctively. Write two sentences explaining it to someone who’s never heard of it, using no jargon.

ENTRY 44

Comparison, Envy, and the Long Table

“Someone else’s acceptance did not use up the last spot at the table.”

— a working note

Envy of another writer’s success — a friend’s book deal, a peer’s prize, a former student’s faster rise — is common enough that pretending you’ll never feel it is not a useful goal. What matters is what you do with it once it shows up.

Literary publishing is not a single table with a fixed number of seats where someone else’s success subtracts from your own chances. It’s closer to an enormous, ongoing potluck with room for a great deal more than anyone assumes on a bad day. Let envy be information — it often points at what you actually want — without letting it become the story you tell yourself about your own prospects.

TRY THIS

Name one writer whose recent success stung a little. Write one honest sentence about what, specifically, you actually want that their success reminded you of.

ENTRY 45

A Long Game: Careers, Not Launches

“If there’s a book you want to read but it hasn’t been written yet, then you must write it.”

— widely attributed to Toni Morrison

A single book’s launch week, however it goes, is a small slice of a much longer arc most working writers are actually engaged in. The writers whose careers last decades tend to treat any one publication — a strong one or a quiet one — as a single data point in a much longer project, not a verdict on the whole enterprise.

This notebook opened with a note about beginning before you’re ready. It closes with its natural complement: keep going after any single outcome, good or bad, because the writing life that matters is the one still being written, sentence by sentence, well past whatever happened today.

TRY THIS

Name one piece of writing you wish existed but haven’t seen anyone write. Write the first paragraph of it tonight.

APPENDIX A

Glossary of Craft Terms

Terms that come up constantly in workshops, editorial letters, and the entries above — collected here so you don't have to interrupt a critique to ask.

Beat

A small unit of action or exchange within a scene — one gesture, one line of dialogue, one shift in attention.

Braided essay

A personal essay that interweaves two or more strands — a personal narrative and a separate subject, image, or thread of research — rather than telling one story straight through.

Denouement

The section after a story's climax where consequences settle and loose threads resolve.

Enjambment

Ending a line of poetry mid-phrase or mid-sentence, so the sense carries over the line break onto the next line.

Epiphany

A moment of sudden recognition or understanding, often the emotional hinge of a short story.

Free indirect discourse

A narrative technique that renders a character's thoughts in the third person and past tense, without quotation marks or an explicit "he thought," blending narrator and character voice.

In medias res

Latin for "into the middle of things" — opening a story already in motion rather than at a strict chronological beginning.

Lyric essay

A short prose form that borrows the compression, associative logic, and attention to language of poetry rather than following a conventional narrative arc.

Persona poem

A poem written in the voice of someone other than the poet — a historical figure, a fictional character, an object.

Scene

A unit of narrative rendered moment-by-moment, in real time, with sensory detail and often dialogue — as opposed to summary.

Simultaneous submission

Sending the same piece to more than one journal, agent, or contest at the same time; standard practice at most literary journals, provided you withdraw promptly elsewhere upon acceptance.

Summary

Narrative compression — telling the reader what happened over a stretch of time, rather than rendering it moment-by-moment as a scene.

Turn (volta)

A pivot in argument, tone, or perspective within a poem, classically located near the end of a sonnet but usable in any form.

Unreliable narrator

A narrator whose account the reader has reason to distrust, whether through self-deception, limited knowledge, or deliberate concealment.

Vignette

A short, self-contained scene or moment, often without conventional plot resolution, frequently used in flash fiction and memoir-in-fragments.

White space

The visual and rhetorical gap left on a page — a line break, a section break, a silence — that asks the reader to supply the connective meaning themselves.

APPENDIX B

Fifty-Four Writing Prompts

*For the days a blank page is the whole problem. These are prompts I've used in *Art of Telling* and handed to my own stalled drafts — pick one at random, or work straight down the list. None of them require an idea to already exist before you sit down.*

FICTION

1. A character receives a letter, text, or voicemail meant for someone else. They read it anyway.
2. Two characters who used to be close run into each other by accident, years after a falling-out neither has ever explained.
3. Write a scene that takes place entirely in a waiting room — of a hospital, a courthouse, a garage.
4. A character is asked to get rid of something that belonged to someone who died. Write what they actually do with it.
5. Someone discovers a family secret while cleaning out a house. Write the moment of discovery only — not the aftermath.
6. Write a story that opens with a character lying to someone they love, and never let the lie be caught.
7. A small object (a key, a photograph, a worn tool) is passed between three different owners across one story.
8. Write a scene in which two characters want opposite outcomes from the same conversation, and neither says so directly.
9. A character returns to a childhood home that's been sold, renovated, or torn down.
10. Write a story told entirely through what a character does with their hands.
11. Two strangers are stuck together — a delayed flight, a stalled elevator, a long car ride — and one of them is hiding something.
12. A character overhears a conversation they weren't supposed to hear, about themselves.
13. Write the last normal day before everything in a character's life changed, without naming what's about to happen.
14. A character has to make a decision in under five minutes that will matter for the next twenty years.
15. Write a scene from the point of view of the character usually treated as the villain of their own family's story.
16. Someone finds an old letter they wrote and never sent. Write the scene where they read it now.
17. A character is the only one at a gathering who knows a piece of information everyone else is about to find out.
18. Write a story that takes place during a single meal, from the first bite to the last.

POETRY

1. Write a poem that names ten specific objects from a single room, and only afterward reveals whose room it is.
2. Write a persona poem in the voice of an object that has outlasted its original owner.

3. Take a piece of overheard speech from your notebook and build a poem entirely around that one line.
4. Write a poem in which every line is a question, and none of them get answered.
5. Write about a color without naming the color itself.
6. Write a poem that takes place entirely during a single, ordinary chore — folding laundry, peeling fruit, sweeping a floor.
7. Write an elegy for something that isn't a person — a demolished building, a discontinued object, a dead language.
8. Write a poem built entirely from instructions (how to do something), that becomes about something else by the end.
9. Write a poem addressed to a version of yourself at a specific, named age.
10. Take the most recent argument you had, real or imagined, and write the poem neither person got to say out loud.
11. Write a poem in which the weather is doing all the emotional work, and never state the emotion directly.
12. Write a poem made only of things you noticed on one walk, in the order you noticed them.
13. Write a poem that starts in a kitchen and ends somewhere the kitchen could never have predicted.
14. Write a poem using a strict form — a sonnet, a villanelle, a ghazal — about the most unglamorous task you did this week.
15. Write a poem that never uses the word 'love,' about someone you love.
16. Write a poem entirely in the second person, addressed to someone who will never read it.
17. Write a poem structured as a list of things you were told not to do as a child.
18. Write a poem about a photograph you've never actually seen, only heard described.

MEMOIR AND PERSONAL ESSAY

1. Write about the first time you realized a parent or guardian was a fallible, ordinary person.
2. Describe a place that no longer exists exactly as you remember it — demolished, renovated, changed hands.
3. Write about an object you've kept for reasons you can't fully explain, and try to explain them anyway.
4. Write the scene of a family meal that went wrong, from the moment before anyone knew it would.
5. Describe a lie you told as a child and what you understood, even then, about why you told it.
6. Write about the last ordinary conversation you had with someone before your relationship with them changed for good.
7. Describe your own body at a specific, uncomfortable age, without apologizing for any of it.
8. Write about a teacher, coach, or mentor who said one specific sentence to you that you still carry.
9. Write about the town, block, or building where you grew up as though a stranger will visit it after reading your piece.
10. Describe the worst advice someone well-meaning ever gave you, and what you did with it anyway.
11. Write about a family story that gets told differently depending on who's telling it, and your version of what actually happened.

12. Describe a moment you were genuinely proud of yourself that you've never told anyone about.
13. Write about the first funeral, wedding, or hospital room you remember being inside of.
14. Describe an argument you're still having with someone, years after the actual conversation ended.
15. Write about a skill, chore, or piece of knowledge someone in your family tried and failed to teach you.
16. Describe the specific contents of a drawer, glovebox, or junk shelf that belonged to someone else, and what it told you about them.
17. Write about a decision you made quickly that changed the course of your life more than any decision you deliberated over.
18. Describe the version of yourself you were embarrassed to be at a specific age — and be specific about why.

APPENDIX C

The Working Writer's Shelf

None of these replace this notebook or the three free submission guides mentioned in the back matter — they go deeper than any single booklet reasonably can. This is the longer list I actually hand students in Art of Telling, organized by the same parts as this notebook, so you can go straight to the shelf that matches what you're working on.

FICTION CRAFT

The Art of Fiction — John Gardner

The clearest account I know of scene, summary, and what Gardner calls the vivid, continuous fictional dream.

Aspects of the Novel — E.M. Forster

Still the sharpest short explanation of the difference between a story and a plot, from the lectures collected in 1927.

Writing Fiction — Janet Burroway

The workshop textbook most creative writing programs actually use, and a genuinely useful reference on point of view and scene construction.

The Art of the Novel — Milan Kundera

Essays on structure, digression, and what the novel can do that no other form can, from a working novelist rather than a theorist.

Story — Robert McKee

Written for screenwriters, but its chapters on structure and the nature of dramatic conflict transfer directly to prose fiction.

POETRY CRAFT

The Poet's Companion — Kim Addonizio and Dorianne Laux

A generous, exercise-driven introduction to the tools of the poetic line, image, and form.

The Triggering Town — Richard Hugo

Short, blunt lectures on where poems actually come from and how to get out of your own way while writing one.

In the Palm of Your Hand — Steve Kowit

An accessible, exercise-heavy guide built for poets who want practical tools over abstract theory.

The Sounds of Poetry — Robert Pinsky

A short, precise handbook on meter, rhythm, and the music underneath a poem's meaning.

Ordinary Genius — Kim Addonizio

A prompt-and-craft guide aimed squarely at poets who want to generate new drafts, not just study finished ones.

MEMOIR AND PERSONAL ESSAY

The Situation and the Story — Vivian Gornick

The essential book on the difference between what happened to you and the story you're actually telling.

Bird by Bird — Anne Lamott

On the discipline and terror of the first draft, and on writing about family without asking anyone's permission first.

Inventing the Truth — edited by William Zinsser

A collection of essays by memoirists on memory, ethics, and the specific difficulty of writing about real people.

The Art of Memoir — Mary Karr

Sharp, funny, and unsentimental about the mechanics of turning lived material into a shaped book.

On Writing Well — William Zinsser

Aimed at nonfiction broadly, but its chapters on voice and simplicity apply directly to personal essay.

REVISION AND STYLE**The Elements of Style — William Strunk Jr. and E.B. White**

Eighty-some pages that will do more for your sentences than most semester-long courses.

Steering the Craft — Ursula K. Le Guin

Short, exacting chapters on point of view, sentence rhythm, and the sound a page makes when it's working.

Self-Editing for Fiction Writers — Renni Browne and Dave King

A chapter-by-chapter checklist approach to the most common structural and line-level problems in a draft.

Several Short Sentences About Writing — Verlyn Klinkenborg

An unconventional, aphoristic book that will change how you think about the sentence as the basic unit of prose.

PUBLISHING AND THE BUSINESS OF WRITING**The Business of Being a Writer — Jane Friedman**

The most current, practically minded overview of how publishing actually works, from query letters to contracts.

The Forest for the Trees — Betsy Lerner

A former editor's account of the editorial and publishing process, and the psychology of working writers.

How to Write a Poetry Collection — Jeremy Noel-Tod

A short, focused guide on the specific problem of ordering and submitting a full manuscript rather than a single poem.

SUSTAINING A WRITING LIFE**The Writing Life — Annie Dillard**

Less a how-to than a meditation on what the daily discipline actually feels like across a career.

On Writing: A Memoir of the Craft — Stephen King

Plain-spoken, practical, and unsentimental about the actual hours the work requires, alongside a genuine memoir.

A Room of One's Own — Virginia Woolf

Still the foundational text on what a writing life actually requires in terms of time, space, and independence.

Big Magic — Elizabeth Gilbert

A warm, accessible case for creative persistence over creative anxiety, useful on the days the work feels impossible.

APPENDIX D

Submission Log

Referenced in Part Six. Track where a piece has gone, when, and what came back — the record turns rejection into data rather than verdict. Redraw this grid in your own notebook, or photocopy this page.

PIECE TITLE	SENT TO	DATE SENT	RESPONSE	DATE HEARD	NOTES

BEFORE YOU GO

Before You Go

That's the whole notebook — forty-five entries across seven parts, meant to be returned to rather than read once and shelved. If even a handful of lines were useful to you this year, it did its job. Keep it near the desk, not on a shelf.

As a member of the Reader's Circle, you'll hear from me when there's real news — a new story or poem out in the world, a session of Art of Telling opening for enrollment, or a new book from Silver Current Press. I keep that list light on purpose; I'd rather send you something worth reading than something merely scheduled.

Thank you again for being here. Now go write something true.

James F. Mulhern

Silver Current Press · authorjamesmulhern.com

ABOUT THE PRESS

About Silver Current Press

Silver Current Press is the independent literary imprint I run out of Philadelphia — fiction, poetry, and craft guides published the way I wish more of them were: honestly, unhurried, and without padding.

If this notebook was useful, three free companions cover ground it only touches on: a short-story submission guide, a poetry submission guide, and a memoir and personal essay submission guide, each with the specifics of format, cover letters, and simultaneous submission etiquette that Part Six only summarizes. All three, along with reading-group guides for every Silver Current Press title, are linked from the Student Guides page at authorjamesmulhern.com.

Art of Telling, the ten-session creative writing salon referenced throughout this notebook, covers short story, poetry, and memoir craft in far more depth than any single booklet could. Details are at art-of-telling.com.